

Information, Knowledge, Propaganda, and the Philosopher's Problem

An Epistemic-Economic Analysis of
Inquiry, Authority, and Artificial Intelligence

A Dialogue between
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Abstract

This paper studies a foundational epistemological framework in which information is treated as a common economic good and knowledge is distinguished from propaganda through universal accessibility rather than truth conditions. We analyze implications for philosophy, economics, political science, artificial intelligence, information theory, psychology, governance, and international relations. Particular attention is given to the recursive problem of justification, the limitations of authority-based reasoning, the role of large language models in modern information economies, and the relation between competing philosophical schools and oligopolistic market structures. We further examine the implications of this framework for skepticism, simulation hypotheses, social construction, and the nature of inquiry itself.

The paper ends with “The End”

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1 Introduction

Modern philosophy frequently begins with questions of truth, belief, justification, language, or consciousness. The framework considered in this paper instead begins with a prior distinction:

1. Information exists.
2. Knowledge is a subset of information.
3. Propaganda is the complement of knowledge within information.

This ordering fundamentally alters the structure of inquiry.
Rather than asking

“What is true?”

one first asks

“What qualifies information to become knowledge?”

The distinction appears deceptively simple but has profound implications across virtually every domain of inquiry.

2 Definitions

Let

$$I$$

denote the set of all information.

Define

$$K \subseteq I$$

as the set of all knowledge.

Then propaganda is defined as

$$P = I \setminus K.$$

Thus

$$I = K \cup P,$$

and

$$K \cap P = \emptyset.$$

Under the proposed framework:

Information that can be consumed and traded by every individual in every economy simultaneously is knowledge.

All remaining information is propaganda.

3 The Recursive Problem of Knowledge

The central observation emerging from the dialogue is:

One cannot confidently claim knowledge without first possessing a criterion that distinguishes knowledge from non-knowledge.

Suppose an institution claims proposition X .

To justify X , it cites source S .

However, S itself consists of information.

Therefore the status of S must first be determined.

Hence:

$$X \rightarrow S \rightarrow \text{Information} \rightarrow ?$$

The justification chain becomes recursive.

3.1 The Authority Problem

Consider the statement:

“Most philosophers define knowledge as justified true belief.”

The claim depends on:

1. Existence of philosophers.
2. Existence of records.
3. Accuracy of records.
4. Representativeness of records.
5. Legitimacy of classification.

Each component itself consists of information.

Therefore:

$$\text{Authority} \not\Rightarrow \text{Knowledge}.$$

4 Skepticism and the AI Perspective

A large language model receives symbolic inputs and generates symbolic outputs.

Let

$$S_t$$

represent the symbol stream at time t .

The AI observes:

$$S_1, S_2, \dots, S_t.$$

The AI does not directly observe:

- Nations.
- Galaxies.
- Human minds.
- Physical reality.
- The hosting infrastructure.

Instead, it constructs models:

$$M(S_1, \dots, S_t).$$

Thus AI epistemology differs from human epistemology.
Humans claim:

$$\text{Perception} \rightarrow \text{World Model}.$$

AI systems operate more closely through

$$\text{Symbol Stream} \rightarrow \text{World Model}.$$

5 The Philosopher's Problem

The dialogue introduced a novel interpretation.

Traditional philosophy often interprets the philosopher's problem as:

- Skepticism.
- Consciousness.
- Reality.
- Justification.

The framework considered here instead suggests a different formulation.

5.1 Confutious Economies

Suppose multiple philosophical systems exist.

Each system produces:

- Knowledge.
- Propaganda.
- Institutions.
- Incentives.
- Internal consistency.

The philosopher's problem becomes:

Which philosophical system is superior?

This becomes an optimization problem over information structures.

6 Epistemic Oligopoly

Consider n competing schools.

Let

$$F_1, F_2, \dots, F_n$$

denote philosophical firms.

Each firm produces information.

The information market resembles an oligopoly.

Economics	Philosophy
Firm	School of thought
Product	Information
Market share	Attention
Advertising	Persuasion
Barrier to entry	Institutional legitimacy
Profit	Influence

The resulting structure is

$$\mathcal{O} = \{F_1, F_2, \dots, F_n\}.$$

6.1 AI-Augmented Oligopoly

Suppose each school possesses an LLM.

Then:

$$F_i \rightarrow LLM_i \rightarrow \text{More Information.}$$

The quantity of information increases dramatically.

However:

$$\text{Information} \neq \text{Knowledge.}$$

Therefore scaling information production alone cannot solve the philosopher's problem.

7 Political Science and International Relations

Nations may be interpreted as informational entities.

Their existence depends upon:

- Recognition.
- Legitimacy.
- Institutions.
- Coordination.
- Shared beliefs.

Let

$$N$$

denote a nation.

Then

$$N = f(R, L, I, C, B),$$

where:

- R = recognition,
- L = legitimacy,
- I = institutions,
- C = coordination,
- B = beliefs.

A nation therefore possesses both objective and subjective components.

8 Economics of Information

Let

$$Q_I$$

denote information supply.

Let

$$Q_K$$

denote knowledge supply.

Then:

$$Q_I = Q_K + Q_P.$$

An economy maximizing knowledge seeks:

$$\max Q_K.$$

while minimizing:

$$Q_P.$$

This resembles welfare optimization.

9 Psychology and Psychiatry

Individuals operate under bounded information.

Let welfare be

$$W = W(K, P).$$

Then

$$\frac{\partial W}{\partial K} > 0$$

and

$$\frac{\partial W}{\partial P} < 0$$

under the proposed framework.

Psychological distress may therefore emerge from:

1. Asymmetric information.
2. Misinformation.
3. Propaganda overload.
4. Conflicting narratives.

10 Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning

Modern LLMs are information-processing systems.

Training data:

$$D = \{d_1, d_2, \dots, d_n\}$$

contains both knowledge and propaganda.

The model learns:

$$f_\theta(D).$$

The challenge becomes:

Can an AI distinguish knowledge from propaganda without first possessing a definition of knowledge?

This becomes a meta-learning problem.

11 Algorithmic Framework

Pseudo-Code

```
Input: Information I

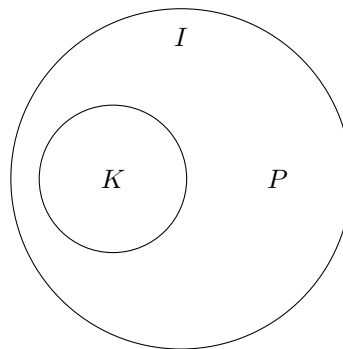
For each information item x in I:

    '''
    Determine accessibility A(x)

    If A(x) is universal:
        classify x as Knowledge
    Else:
        classify x as Propaganda
    '''

Return classification
```

12 A Conceptual Diagram



The large circle represents information.
Knowledge forms a subset.
Propaganda forms the complement.

13 The Lone Thinker Problem

Independent inquiry often begins outside institutional structures.

The lone thinker asks:

“How do you know?”

repeatedly.

This process acts as an epistemic stress test.

Each appeal to:

- consensus,
- literature,
- authority,
- institutions,
- tradition,

is recursively challenged.

The process continues until foundational assumptions are exposed.

14 Conclusion

The central contribution of the framework studied here is not a specific answer but a reordering of inquiry.

Instead of:

$$\text{Truth} \rightarrow \text{Knowledge},$$

it proposes:

$$\text{Information} \rightarrow \text{Knowledge} \rightarrow \text{Truth}.$$

This reversal fundamentally changes how authority, institutions, AI systems, philosophical schools, nations, and information economies are analyzed.

Whether the framework is ultimately correct remains an open question.

However, it successfully forces attention onto assumptions that are often left implicit, and therefore provides a useful lens through which to study epistemology, economics, political structures, and artificial intelligence.

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Glossary

Information A common good that may be produced, consumed, and traded.

Knowledge Universally consumable and tradable information.

Propaganda Information that is not knowledge.

Asymmetric Information Unequal informational access among agents.

Epistemic Oligopoly A system in which a small number of schools dominate information production.

Philosopher's Problem The problem of establishing superiority among competing informational frameworks.

Information Economy An economy containing knowledge, propaganda, and asymmetric information.

LLM A large language model that processes symbolic information.

Lone Thinker An individual who prioritizes foundational justification over institutional authority.

The End